

Sunset beckons: Atrachali (third from right) doesn't shy away from admitting his career is heading towards its twilight phase, which explains why the need to succeed and to err minimally have become so crucial to his operation on the mat. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



player making life difficult for Indians in a sport they gave to the world.

With time, he has moved on from individual pursuits to finding solace in his pack, something he believes is the way an achiever naturally progresses in team sports.

"I am always thinking about where we can score or save points. Sometimes, I am constantly talking to players but no one is talking to me. When you are captain, no one cares about guiding you," he reveals.

"I do have phases where I am nervous about what will happen next for me in life or during a tournament. It helps to have Nabibakhsh, who is also my roommate here, with me. I tell him, 'If I don't know what to do sometimes, you tell me'," he says.

"Everyone is saying a lot of things about my leadership and my records. At the end of it all, though, I

am a player. I also make mistakes. The good thing about the coach is that he adds me to his instructions. He pushes me to try and not worry about the consequences. There will be games when Fazel might not be good, and then someone else needs to step up. If only one or two players are going to work, you are more of a weakness for your side than a strength," the veteran defender explains.

Atrachali recognises his career's twilight phase, emphasising the importance of success and minimal errors in his performance on the mat. Thinking for seven instead of one doesn't make that job any easier.

"Before this season, I met Pawan (Sehrawat) in Mumbai for a shoot. He noticed some white hair on my head and said, 'Fazel, you've become old; you're greying'. I said to him, 'You haven't been captain for too long, so

you don't understand'. This conversation happened over a month or so ago. A few days back, I met Pawan again, and the first thing he showed me was his own white hair, saying, 'Fazel look. I understand now'. Life is difficult as a captain."

Two sides of a coin

Atrachali and Shadloui represent two ends of the same spectrum. Given the increasing calls to broaden kabaddi to more countries, the tremendous success of such personalities and how unafraid they are to show the highs and lows of the stardom that comes with it are as crucial to players as they are to fans consuming the sport.

The Sultan, as Atrachali's moniker in kabaddi goes, may have his successor in Shadloui, but that both still have plenty to give back to the sport means its present and future are well and truly secure.